

AI in Project Controls: A Practical Playbook

How to get real value from AI in scheduling, cost, forecasting and reporting — with the governance that keeps the numbers defensible. Background: [AI in project controls](#).

1. Use cases and the review they need

Area	Good uses today	Keep a human on	Review level
Scheduling	Draft activity lists from scope; compare updates; group quality-check failures; suggest likely missing links	Logic, durations, baseline changes	High
Schedule quality	Run and summarise DCMA-style checks every update	Accepting exceptions	Medium
Cost	Map cost lines to control accounts; flag unusual postings and missing accruals	Corrections to the ledger	Medium
Forecasting	Pattern-based EAC ranges from your history; driver analysis; scenarios	The reported EAC and its basis	High
Risk	De-duplicate registers; draft risk descriptions; summarise trends	Probability, impact, contingency	High
Progress	Cross-check claims against deliveries, inspections and photos	Rules of credit; accepted progress	High
Reporting	Draft narratives from verified data; consistency checks across sections	Causes, actions, recommendations	Medium

2. Governance checklist — agree before using AI on live data

- ☐ **Allowed uses** written down (e.g. drafting, review, narrative: yes; automatic baseline changes: no).
- ☐ **Approved tools and data handling**: which data may be sent to which tool; where it is stored.
- ☐ **Human review**: every AI-proposed change to logic, durations, forecasts or progress is approved by a named person.
- ☐ **Labelling**: AI-assisted sections of reports are marked as such.
- ☐ **Audit trail**: inputs, prompts or model versions and reviewer decisions are recorded.
- ☐ **Validation**: predictions are compared with outcomes; features that do not help are dropped.
- ☐ **Fallback**: the team can still produce the update and report without the tool.

Turn this into a team policy with [our AI governance policy template](#).

3. Prompt patterns that stay grounded

Use only the data provided: “Using only the attached export, list activities whose finish moved by more than 10 working days, grouped by WBS, with old and new dates. Say if anything is missing.”

Explain, then flag uncertainty: “Draft a 150-word explanation of what drives the finish date. Mark any statement you could not verify from the data.”

Check, don't change: “List activities without successors (excluding the finish milestone) and suggest which might need a link to handover. Do not propose durations.”

Compare with the formulas: “Compare this forecast with $BAC \div CPI$ and $AC + (BAC - EV) \div (CPI \times SPI)$. Explain any gap above 3%.”

More prompts: [AI prompts for project managers](#).

4. Review workflow for AI-assisted reports

1. Produce the numbers from controlled systems (schedule, cost ledger, risk register).
2. Run automated checks; fix data problems first.
3. Ask the AI to compare, summarise and draft — from the verified data only.
4. Control account managers correct causes and actions; the AI cannot know why work slipped.
5. Label AI-assisted content; a named owner signs off the report.

5. A 30-day pilot plan

Week	What to do
1 — baseline	Pick one project and one use case. Record how long the task takes today and what it usually finds.
2 — set up	Confirm the tool is approved for the data; write allowed uses; name the reviewer.
3 — run in parallel	Do the task both ways. Compare time, issues found, false alarms and errors.
4 — decide	Keep, adjust or drop. If kept, document the workflow and review step.

6. Measures of success

- Hours saved per reporting cycle, with quality unchanged or better.
- Genuine issues found that the old process missed.
- Forecast accuracy against outcomes (back-tested on completed projects).
- Zero unreviewed AI changes to baselines or reported numbers.

Deeper dives: [AI for project scheduling](#) · [AI cost forecasting](#) · [Project controls monthly report](#).

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